



Jain's biggest challenge as a CEO probably came when the Covid-19-induced lockdowns forced people and employees to stay at home. "If you create a crisis, you can't solve that crisis; but if you didn't create that crisis, that gives you a far greater moral right to solve that crisis," he told his senior management teams. "It was a crisis that all of us, as operating managers, looked at from that philosophical lens and went towards solving it and even gaining from it."

The company's growth journey was in some ways cut short by the raging pandemic waves, but it also showed remarkable resilience. In the BT-PwC India's Best CEOs ranking data, Bajaj Finance's three-year CAGR in total income was calculated at 22.99 per cent, and in profit after tax, 16.73 per cent. Asset quality was also under control, with net NPAs at 0.91 per cent of loans as of March 31, 2021. This exceptional performance, which includes the first pandemic year, led the four-member jury to confer on Jain the highest honour of 'Champion of Champions'.

When Jain joined the company in 2007,

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Key Highlights

- ❶ Devised new strategy to transform through digital inclusion
- ❷ Navigated the company safely through two difficult years of the Covid-19 pandemic
- ❸ Kept asset quality under control with net NPAs at 0.91 per cent
- ❹ Raised capital of \$1.2 billion just before the pandemic
- ❺ Scaled up subsidiaries

TOP OF THE GAME Rajeev Jain, MD, Bajaj Finance